Workshop Exercise: Argument Extraction: Mortimer on the Divine Command Theory

Passage taken from:
Mortimer, Robert C. (1950/2013), *Christian Ethics.* New York: Routledge.

[For instructions and/or guidance, see the next page.]

Bishop Robert Mortimer:

p.5 The Christian religion has a clear revelation of the nature of God, and by means of it instructs and enlightens the consciences of men. The first foundation is the doctrine of God the Creator. God made us and all the world. Because of that he has an absolute claim on our obedience. We do not exist in our own right, but only as His creatures, who ought therefore to do and be what He desires. We do not possess anything in the world, absolutely, not even our own bodies ; we hold things in trust for God, who created them, and are bound, therefore, to use them only as He intends
p.6 that they should be used. This is the doctrine contained in the first chapters of Genesis. God created man and placed him in the Garden of Eden with all the animals and the fruits of the earth at his disposal, subject to God's own law. "Of the fruit of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil thou shall not eat." Man's ownership and use of the material world is not absolute, but subject to the law of God.

From the doctrine of God as the Creator and source of all that is, it follows that a thing is not right simply because we think it is, still less because it seems to be expedient. It is right because God commands it.

Background / Set up

State the argument in outline

Explain Any Rationales for the Premises

Evaluate the argument

Instructions: Your aim in these exercises is to fill in the framework on the right side of this page. Essentially, you are writing a mini essay that is based on the brief text provided! Here is some advice (or direction) about what I'm trying to get you to do:

(1) **Background:** Don't worry too much about this item. It's mostly there to remind you that, if this were a real essay, you would want to set up the topic for the reader. For instance, you might use this space explain to the reader what the divine command theory says, since that's what Mortimer's text is about. (You could also use it to describe a thought experiment, if there is one that is relevent to the argument.)

(2) **Stating the argument in outline.** Here you want to briefly lay out the argument's conclusion, and the main premises of the argument. Ideally, you could do this with three or four sentences. (I try to give you simple arguments for these exercises. But arguments can have many more premises).

(2.1) Although it is standard to write **the conclusion** *last* in an argument outline, it's usually a good idea for you to begin by trying to understand what the author's conclusion is (or is supposed to be). That is, when trying to work out what the author's premises are---i.e., the claims that they are relying on to convince you of the conclusion---it helps enormously if you know WHAT they are trying to convince you of.

(2.2) Next, you want to identify the **key premises** that the are offering in support of their conclusion: What reason (or reasons) are they giving you for believing or accepting their conclusion? Sometimes, the author could be relying on a premise that is unstated---perhaps they think its obvious and no one will dispute it. But it's stil good for you to make those unstated premises explicit. Sometimes they are more controversial than the author realizes!

(2.3) If you've identified the conclusion and one or more premises, then you can write them into the section on the right that says "State the argument in outline". (Again, it's standard to write the conclusion last when givingan argument outline).

(3) Rationales for the Premises. In many cases (though not all cases), there is more to be said about a premise. In this section of the worksheet, you can expand on that, if need be. For instance, does the premise make use of a technical term in philosophy? If it does, you can define that term here. Or perhaps the premise in quesition asserts a connection between two ideas. In that case, the rationale might involve explaining why the one idea follows from the other. Etc.

(4) Evaluation of the argument. Here, the question is whether you found the argument convincing or not. If you *did* find it convincing, there might not be much to say in the evaluation section. But if you weren't convinced, this is the place to say what you think is wrong with the argument: (A) Does the conclusion not follow from it's premises? (B) Does one (or more) of its premises seem doubtful to you? Why? (Even if you agree with an argument, it's a useful exercise to try to imagine why someone else might reasonably reject it.)

(An extra answer sheet, in case you want to try again)

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